

spoken on the need to be good managers of the material things God has provided. *I sure wish I had listened better*, Bill said to himself.

Bill and Andrea described the events of the past several months that had brought them to the point where they were. Mike made several notes as they discussed the particular events.

“As I see it,” he said, “you have several symptoms and two basic problems.”

“What do you mean?” Andrea asked. “What’s the difference?”

“The problems created the symptoms,” he responded. “For instance, you now owe nearly five thousand dollars in consumer debt. But that’s a symptom of a much deeper problem, I believe. If your parents just gave you the money to pay the bills, I believe they would be doing you a disservice, because it’s likely that you would repeat the same mistakes again.”

“Not me,” Andrea said emphatically.

“I know that’s what you think right now,” he said. “And probably you wouldn’t repeat the exact same mistakes. But indulgence comes in many forms, and future mistakes can create much more severe consequences. I’ve seen people who make more than \$150,000 a year get deeply into debt because their impulses grew even faster than their salaries.

“I think I can help you get out from under the circumstances, if you’re willing to sacrifice for a while. But unless you recognize the problems and solve them, you’ll be back again.”

“What do you think the problems are?” Bill asked.

“As I see it, Bill, your problem stems from a lack of self-confidence. But it shows itself in the fact that you haven’t accepted your responsibility as the head of your family.”

“What do you mean?”

“First you allowed yourself to be talked into a quick elopement, and because you didn’t want to hurt Andrea’s feelings, you weren’t honest with her. No sound relationship can ever be built on a